Task: - 5

Cybercrime Case Study – UPI/Online Payment Fraud

As a Student Digital Ambassador, I have chosen to focus on **UPI/Online Payment Fraud**, a prevalent cybercrime targeting mobile users in India.

What the Crime Is UPI fraud involves the unauthorized transfer of funds from a victim's bank account using the Unified Payments Interface (UPI) ecosystem. Unlike traditional hacking, this crime typically relies on **social engineering** to trick the user into authorizing a transaction they believe is a credit or a refund.

How It Typically Happens (Step-by-Step)

1. **The Bait:** The fraudster poses as a buyer on an e-commerce platform (like OLX) or a customer care executive.
2. **The Request:** They send a "Request Money" link or a QR code to the victim, claiming it is for "payment verification" or to "receive" money.
3. **The Trap:** The victim is instructed to scan the QR code and enter their **UPI PIN**.
4. **The Theft:** Since a PIN is only required to *send* money, not receive it, entering the PIN instantly authorizes a debit from the victim's account to the fraudster's account.

Who is Usually Targeted While anyone using digital payments is at risk, students and young professionals who frequently use peer-to-peer selling apps or seek quick online refunds are primary targets.

The Consequences Victims face immediate financial loss, often ranging from a few thousand to several lakhs of rupees. Beyond the money, it leads to a loss of trust in digital systems and potential identity exposure if the fraudster gains access to linked mobile apps.